

The objective data make it quite clear. In America, the odds are against women earning high incomes. Some of this variation in income can certainly be explained by biases in the economic marketplace. But biases alone do not fully explain the fact that there are five men for every one woman in the top 1 percent of the earned income distribution. Could it be that the tendency for affluent parents to subsidize their daughters is helping to perpetuate this inequality?

Daughters of wealthy couples tend not to have careers of their own. Why? In the past twenty years, the affluent population has typically been composed of one type of household: More than 80 percent have been married couples with children in which the wife did not work full time. What message did this send to the daughters of such couples? Simply stated: “Mother did not work (and the marriage survived), so perhaps I should not work.” It is difficult to argue with such logic. The traditional affluent family system does, in fact, function quite well. Affluent couples have a divorce rate that is less than half the norm.

The “father works, the mother mothers and does everything else for her family” system is very often copied by the female products of such marriages. Many affluent parents actually encourage their daughters not to work, not to have their own careers, and not to be economically and psychologically independent. Affluent parents instill this “dependence” characteristic in their daughters over time with subtle cues. Thus, many affluent parents communicate messages such as the following to their daughters:

Don't worry.... If you don't want to have a career of your own, ... you don't have to worry about money. We will help you out financially.... If you do have a career, ... if you do become a big success ... and become independent, you will not be receiving any major financial gifts or inheritance from us.